

The AI Tool Landscape — Beyond ChatGPT

CSPS AI Training Workshop · 24–28 August 2026 · a companion sheet, not a ranking

How to read this sheet. All of these tools are capable general assistants — the differences that matter day-to-day are *where they live* (inside your documents? grounded in your sources?) and *what they are best at*. The skills you learn this week (clear instructions, data discipline, verification) transfer to every one of them. Capabilities change fast; treat this as a map drawn in August 2026, not a permanent atlas.

Tool	What it is	Everyday work	Research use
ChatGPT OpenAI	The most widely used general assistant; strong all-rounder with data-analysis and image features.	Drafting, brainstorming, summaries, spreadsheet help.	Exploratory analysis, coding help; verify sources it cites.
Claude Anthropic	Assistant known for careful long-form writing and working through long documents.	Reports and memos; reading long PDFs; polished tone.	Literature synthesis, structured analysis, code for data work.
Gemini Google	Google's assistant, integrated with Gmail, Docs and Drive; strong multimodal features.	Working inside Google Workspace; translation; images and video understanding.	Deep-research style sourced reports; verify before citing.
Copilot Microsoft	Assistant built into Windows, Edge and (with licences) Word, Excel and Outlook.	Drafting inside Office files; email triage; meeting recaps.	Less research-focused; useful where your data already lives in Office.
NotebookLM Google	A source-grounded notebook: it answers ONLY from documents you upload, with citations — and can turn them into an audio overview.	Briefings grounded in your own reports; onboarding packs.	The safest of these for document-bound Q&A; still read the cited passage.
Perplexity Perplexity AI	A search-first assistant: answers come with linked web sources by default.	Quick oriented lookups with references to check.	First-pass scans of a topic; every citation must be opened and read.

The rules that do not change, whichever tool you use

- **Three-way data sort:** Public — paste freely · Internal — anonymise first · Confidential — never into a public tool.
- **Verify before you rely:** find one thing to fix in every output; source-shaped text is not a source.
- **Instruct in five parts:** Role · Task · Context · Constraints · Format — works identically in all six tools.
- **Pick by task, not by loyalty:** long document → Claude/NotebookLM · inside Office → Copilot · inside Google → Gemini · sourced scan → Perplexity.